

He shook his head. "I ship to the freight forwarder. He's in the Buenos Aires warehouse district."

"He'll call me when the shipment comes in?"

He shook his head. "They're not reliable. It's better to run over there every few days to check if the wine has arrived. You can try to call, but it's hard to get through by phone."

"Can't he just deliver to me?"

He shook his head. "Too expensive. He charges more to ship from his warehouse to your apartment than from Mendoza to Buenos Aires. Better go pick it up yourself. Just track down a friend with a truck. Or maybe you can rent a car with a big trunk. . . ."

Like many deals in Argentina, this one didn't get done. It's pretty hard to sell without a way to take an order, make delivery, or receive payment.

The wine story illustrates how hard it can be to get something done in Argentina. Some of the most pleasant places in the world can be hell if you have to go to an office and struggle. Routine things in the Third World almost never happen in a routine way. Even top executives spend their days tracking down cash transfers, collecting overdue accounts, and signing government forms.

But working in the Third World is one thing. Retiring is quite another. Business requires infrastructure: money wires, banking services, phones, mail delivery, and computers. When those things break down, you get frustrated. But those frustrations are only minor blips if you're retired. Retirement, as we'll see in chapter 8, requires hardly any infrastructure at all. Retirees walk over to visit friends rather than talk to them on the phone. In the afternoon they go to a café rather than to a bank. They write personal letters rather than crank masterpieces out of a word processor.

Forget what you may have heard about tough times in the Third World. You've been talking to disgruntled businessmen. You're going to retire rather than work. You retire to beaches, mountains, or ranches rather than to offices or